

iPhone and BlackBerry

At the pwn2own contest, an iPhone 4 and BlackBerry were hacked raising concerns over mobile security, especially smartphones

Fake Android

Antivirus company Symantec has reportedly discovered a fake Google Android security patch

Cover feature

At the code level

Exploit	note	push	soft	window	mark
Versions	older than 2.3	older than 2.3	older than 2.3	older than 2.3	older than 2.3
Modus operandi	Sends text messages to premium-rate numbers. If a mobile number is specified, the mobile's number is sent to a remote server to check if it has been blacklisted. In case it is, the message won't be sent. The URL of the service has to be sent as a parameter to the command and the blacklist check will be performed issuing a request. For details, go to tinyurl.com/droid-vul .	Performs SMS-spamming and requires parameters such as 'text message', the target 'URL', and target mobile number.	This command is used to install packages on to the compromised device. The packages are downloaded from a remote URL that has to be sent along with the command as a parameter.	Makes the mobile navigate to a given web site via a browser with the following order of preference: UC, tencent, Opera Mini for Android, Tunny and default Android browser	Adds bookmarks to the compromised device. When the service is first launched, the following bookmarks are added to the device: android.paojiao.cn , ct2.paojiao.cn , and g3g3.cn .
Fix	tinyurl.com/droid-ggl	tinyurl.com/droid-ggl	tinyurl.com/droid-ggl	tinyurl.com/droid-ggl	tinyurl.com/droid-ggl

Fake Player Codec

Poses as a media player application, but once installed starts sending premium rate text messages.

Geinimi

Poses as a legitimate application and is the first Android malware in the wild that displays botnet-like capabilities. Once the malware is installed on a user's phone, it has the potential to receive commands from a remote server that allows the owner of that server to control the phone. In such a situation, an attacker can remotely send location co-ordinates of the user, transmit device identifiers, install malicious applications, read or send text messages, access email or corporate data if the user has such data on the device – in short potentially access and use any device, personal or corporate information that is on the phone for malicious gains.

Mobspy.A

Another Android-based malware that steals information such as both incoming and outgoing phone numbers, incoming and outgoing SMS messages and GPS location.

Google's response

The Android team was made aware of and removed from Android Market a number of malicious apps. We have since taken measures to protect our users by automatically undoing the exploits and contacting law enforcement agencies. The details of our security efforts as listed on the official Google blog (tinyurl.com/droid-ggl).

Although all platforms are vulnerable to attacks, hackers prefer the most popular and widely consumed platforms as their primary target. Krishnapur added, "Literally all mobile platforms are vulnerable. The fragility of mobile platforms is proven and exploitation of vulnerabilities is clearly on the rise. No vendor or mobile OS is immune. It does not matter if it is Symbian, Windows Mobile, iOS,

market which are being picked up at a much lower cost. Once purchased, the cost to the user to "unlock" / "jailbroken devices" the phone is just a couple of thousand rupees or lower. The users done realise that by "unlocking" an iPhone, they are not only violating the warranty, but more importantly compromising the security of the product and making themselves more vulnerable to new attacks.



"Google's Android tried to keep pace with the iPhone in terms of functionality, and as devices diversify, the Android user base continues to grow. In early 2010, Google found and removed banking malware from a site when a wallpaper application gathered information on over 1 million Android users."

Altaf Halde, Country Director, Sophos

Blackberry, Java or Android. In 2009-10, threats to Symbian were the highest, followed by J2E, Android and Windows.

However, at this time Android is rapidly growing as a platform of choice for both vendors and customers. Hackers typically tend to target the most widely used platforms as their intent is to maximise gain. Also given that it is in the early stages of infancy as a platform combined with its increasing popularity it is very likely that attacks on Android will significantly increase in the years to come.

According to Halde, "it's a known fact that the iPhone costs higher in the Indian market compared to the overseas market. Due to this, we have seen a lot of "imported" iPhones coming in the grey

What to expect?

In terms of security, Android is a work in progress. Unlike desktop computing, where openness went in favour of free operating systems, it seems to be a disadvantage for Android. Closed systems such as iOS with a dedicated team to approve developer contributed apps seem to offer better security features. But again, in order to get the iPhone for cheap, users end up compromising with security by resorting to jailbreaking. Even Android users, compromise with security by indulging in rooting their OS to enjoy updates before their official release in the region. Hopefully with Gingerbread and subsequent flavours of Android, Google would pull up their socks. **d**